C1 Vocabulary

Hedging: sounding careful and precise

Soften claims in essays and discussions so you sound measured and academic rather than absolute.

Strong claims such as *Social media destroys friendships* are easy to attack. Academic and professional writers *hedge*: they show how sure they are and limit a claim to what the evidence supports.

Type	Language	Example
Modal verbs	may, might, could, would	*This may lead to higher costs.*
Tentative verbs	appear to, seem to, tend to, suggest	*The results suggest that sleep affects memory.*
Adverbs	arguably, possibly, probably, largely	*This is arguably the most important factor.*
Limiting quantity	some, many, in most cases, to some extent	*In many cases, remote work improves productivity.*
Impersonal phrases	It is likely that, It could be argued that	*It could be argued that exams measure memory, not skill.*

Hedge, then commit. Too much hedging sounds weak. Hedge claims about causes and the future, but state clear facts plainly: *The study involved 2,000 students*, not *The study seems to have possibly involved…*

Common mistake. Stacking hedges: *It might possibly perhaps be true*. One hedge per claim is usually enough: *It might be true.*

Practice

Rewrite each claim with one hedge.

1. Video games cause violent behaviour.
2. Everyone prefers working from home.
3. The new law will reduce crime.
4. Correct the over-hedging: This could possibly perhaps suggest a link.
5. Which sentence should not be hedged? (a) Prices will rise next year. (b) The survey was carried out in March.

▼ **Show answers**

1. Video games may contribute to violent behaviour in some players.
2. Many people appear to prefer working from home.
3. The new law is likely to reduce crime.
4. This could suggest a link. / This suggests a possible link.
5. (b) It is a plain fact.